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## The structure of Kanuri society

**Author(S):** Cohen, Ronald

**Document Type:** Book

**Original Page:** 69

**Culture (OWC):** [Kanuri \(MS14\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Western Africa

**Field Date:** 1956-1957

**Coverage Date:** 1956-1957

**Place Coverage:** Magumeri, Borno State, Nigeria

**Section Title(S):** Joking Relationships (Suli)

It is not uncommon to see a grandparent visiting his or her friends always in the company of their little joking partners. As the friends sit down to chat of the latest gossip of the day, the grandchild plays nearby, then comes over and nestles in the grandparent's arms, pulls at articles of dress on his person, or pulls at grandfather's beard, and acts generally in a quietly affectionate manner. The observer is struck more with the genuine fondness and affection of the relationship, at its early stages, than with its so-called joking content. As the child grows older the joking aspect becomes more noticeable. The grandparent will point out a young playmate of the opposite sex and say to him - **70** that is your wife, is it?, or to her - that is your husband, eh? All the restrictions on any show of emotion with own parents are noticeable by their absence in the affective nature of the grandparent joking relationship with its openly expressible fondness and friendship. That there is some discipline involved is indicated by the fact that the child is very often socialized in a grandparent's house. One grandparent was observed very patiently taking the left hand of his little namesake out of the food bowl, every time the child attempted to eat with this taboo instrument. One adult informant summed up his own attitudes towards the relationship as follows:

You may pull your kaka's (grandparent's) beards, or go into his house and take his possessions, and he will not mind - he is happy because his children have borne children. If you have a yeiya (great-grandparent) alive, it is the same with him.

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*755 Prospect Street  
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs:  [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



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